Policy Name	Volunteer Manual and Policy
Policy Number	IV. Public 7
Application	All Staff and Volunteers
Date Issued	December 16, 2008
Effective Date	December 17, 2008

I. Policy Statement

The organization encourages the teamwork of staff and volunteers to offer customers the best services possible. Volunteers do not replace paid staff, but support and extend the services of the company. Volunteers contribute their unique talents, skills and knowledge of their communities to support and assist staff in their responsibilities, to provide personalized attention to customers and to educate other members of their community about the company and its mission. The Organization is committed to providing a wide array of volunteer opportunities and to integrating the work of volunteers at all levels of the organization. The work of volunteers, excluding those recruited by Literacy or Programs and Exhibitions, is managed by the Office of Volunteer Resources.

Note: Volunteer Tutors in the Literacy Program are selected and supervised by Literacy Program staff. Volunteers who present programs at the company organized by Programs & Exhibitions are recruited and supervised by the Department of Programs & Exhibitions.

II. Regulations

The Volunteer Program

Purpose of Volunteer Guidelines

The purpose of these policies is to provide overall guidance and direction to staff and volunteers engaged in volunteer involvement and management efforts. These policies are intended for internal management guidance only, and do not constitute, either implicitly or explicitly, a binding contractual or personnel agreement. The Company reserves the exclusive right to change any of these guidelines at any time and to expect adherence to the changed guidelines. Changes to or exceptions from these guidelines may only be granted by Volunteer Resources and must be obtained in advance and in writing. Areas not specifically covered by these guidelines shall be determined by Volunteer Resources.

Scope of Volunteer Guidelines

Unless specifically stated, these guidelines apply to all volunteers in all programs and projects undertaken on or on behalf of the company, and to all departments.

Role of Volunteer Resources

The productive utilization of volunteers requires a planned and organized effort. The function of Volunteer Resources is to provide a central coordinating point for effective volunteer management within the company, and to direct and assist staff and volunteer efforts to jointly provide more productive services. The Manager of Volunteer Resources shall bear primary responsibility for planning for effective volunteer utilization, assisting staff in identifying productive and creative volunteer roles, recruiting suitable volunteers, and tracking and evaluating the contribution of volunteers to the organization.

Definition of Volunteer

A volunteer is anyone who, without compensation or expectation of compensation beyond reimbursement, performs a task at the direction of and on behalf of the organization. A volunteer must be officially accepted and enrolled by prior to performance of the task. Volunteers are members of the staff, however, volunteers shall not be considered as employees of the organization.

Special Case Volunteers

BPL also accepts volunteers who participate in student intern projects, alternative sentencing or diversion programs, corporate volunteer programs, and other volunteer referral programs. In each of these cases, however, a special agreement must be in effect with the organization, school, or program from whom the special case volunteers originate and must identify responsibility for management and care of the volunteers. All agreements must be sent to Volunteer Resources for review. Volunteer Resources will seek the approval of legal counsel prior to returning the service agreement. Supervisors should contact Volunteer Resources if they need the company to create a new affiliate agreement.

Employees as Volunteers

the company accepts the services of staff as volunteers. This service is accepted provided that the volunteer service is provided totally without any coercive nature, involves work which is outside the scope of normal staff duties, and is provided outside of usual working hours. Family members of staff are allowed to volunteer with the company. When family members are enrolled as volunteers, they will not be placed under the direct supervision or within the same department as other members of their family who are employees.

Service at the Discretion of the organization

The organization accepts the service of all volunteers with the understanding that such service is at the sole discretion of the organization. Volunteers agree that the company may at any time, for whatever reason, decide to terminate the volunteer's relationship with the company.

The volunteer may at any time, for whatever reason, decide to sever the volunteer's relationship with the organization. Notice of such a decision should be communicated as soon as possible to the volunteer's supervisor.

Volunteer Rights and Responsibilities

Volunteers are viewed as a valuable resource to thecompany, its staff, and its customers. Volunteers shall be extended the right to be given meaningful assignments, the right to be treated as equal co-workers, the right to effective supervision, the right to full involvement and participation, and the right to recognition for work done.

Volunteers are entitled to use staff lounges and bathrooms. Staff should identify a secure place for volunteers to keep their personal belongings.

Volunteers are expected to actively perform their duties to the best of their abilities and adhere to the company policies and procedures. These policies include, but are not limited to, Custodianship of Materials Policy (Organization #12), Anti-Harassment Policy (HR #08), Drug and Alcohol Policy (HR #21), and Workplace Violence Policy (HR #24).

Prior to any action or statement which might significantly affect or obligate the company, volunteers should seek prior consultation and approval from appropriate staff. These actions may include, but are not limited to, public statements to the press, coalition or lobbying efforts with other organizations, or any agreements involving contractual or other financial obligations. Volunteers are authorized to act as representatives of the company as specifically indicated within their job descriptions and only to the extent of such written specifications.

Volunteers are responsible for maintaining the confidentiality of all proprietary or privileged information to which they are exposed while serving as a volunteer, whether this information involves a single staff, volunteer, patron or other person or involves overall business. Failure to maintain confidentiality may result in termination of the volunteer's relationship with the organization or other corrective action.
As representatives of the organization, volunteers, like staff, are responsible for presenting a good image to customers and to the community. Volunteers shall dress appropriately for the conditions and performance of their duties.

Scope of Volunteer Involvement
Volunteers may be engaged in all programs and activities of the company. Volunteers may not be utilized to displace any paid employees from their positions.

Board of Trustees
Members of BPL's Board of Trustees are not accepted as direct service volunteers with the organization.

Conflict of Interest
No person who has a conflict of interest with any activity or program of the company, whether personal, philosophical, or financial shall be accepted or serve as a volunteer with the organization.

III. Procedures and Guidelines

Volunteer Management Procedures

Maintenance of Records
A system of records will be maintained on each volunteer with the company, including dates of service, positions held, duties performed, evaluation of work, and awards received. Volunteers and appropriate staff shall be responsible for submitting all appropriate records and information to Volunteer Resources in a timely and accurate fashion.

Volunteer personnel records shall be accorded the same confidentiality as staff personnel records.

Applications, Timesheets, and Volunteer Code of Conduct
All volunteer candidates must fill out a Volunteer Application (#273.00). This application is available from the Office of Volunteer Resources and may be filled out. Applications are available for print on the intranet and website. Candidates may also submit an electronic

application to Volunteer Resources through website. If an application is filled out at a company, it should be forwarded to Volunteer Resources so that an interview can be scheduled and information about the volunteer can be entered into the Volunteer Management System.
All volunteers between the ages of 12 and 18 are required to present written parental/guardian permission to volunteer on the application. Minors may not work during regularly scheduled school hours or more than the hours allowed by the NYS Department of Labor. (This information is available through the Office of Volunteer Resources.)

All prospective volunteers are required to review and sign Volunteer Code of Conduct prior to their acceptance at a volunteer.

All volunteers are required to complete a Monthly Volunteer Time Sheet (#273.04). These time sheets record the number of hours worked each day, tasks performed, and the number of customers served daily. Time sheets should be approved by the supervisor and submitted to Volunteer Resources at the end of each month.

Volunteer Recruitment and Selection

Position Descriptions
Volunteer staff, just as paid staff, require a clear, complete, and current description of the duties and responsibilities of the position which they are expected to fill. Prior to any volunteer assignment or recruitment effort, a position description must be developed for each volunteer position. This description will be given to each accepted volunteer and utilized in subsequent management and evaluation efforts. Position descriptions should be reviewed and updated at least every two years, or whenever the work involved in the position changes substantially.

All position descriptions shall include a description of the purpose and duties of the position, a timeframe for the performance of the job, a listing of job qualifications, and a description of job benefits. The Volunteer Department is available to assist staff in the development of volunteer jobs and position descriptions. Current volunteer assignment descriptions are posted on the intranet.

Staff Requests for Volunteers
Requests for volunteers shall be submitted in writing by interested staff, complete with a draft position description and a requested timeframe. All parties should understand that the recruitment of volunteers is enhanced by creative and interesting jobs and by advance notice. Volunteer Resources reserves the right to refuse to recruit or place any volunteers until staff is prepared to make effective use of volunteer resources.

Recruitment
Volunteers shall be recruited by the organization on a pro-active basis, with the intent of broadening and expanding the volunteer involvement of the community. Volunteers shall be recruited without regard to gender, disability, age, race or other condition. The sole qualification for volunteer recruitment shall be suitability to perform a task on behalf of the company. Volunteers may be recruited through either an interest in specific functions or through a general interest in volunteering which will later be matched with a specific function. No final acceptance of a volunteer shall take place without a volunteer position description for that volunteer.

Volunteer Resources is responsible for recruitment of volunteers as requested by any Agency or Department for short-term or long-term assignments. Agencies and Departments may recruit volunteers at the local level in consultation with Volunteer Resources. Any Agency or Department needing a volunteer should complete a Volunteer Request Form (#273.03) and forward it to the Volunteer Resources. Volunteer Resources will recruit through online postings, fliers, communication with local community based organizations and by word of mouth.

Recruitment of Minors

Volunteers under 18 years old must have the written consent of a parent of guardian prior to volunteering. The volunteer services assigned to a minor should comply with all appropriate requirements of child labor laws.

Interviewing

Prior to being assigned or appointed to a position, the organization will interview all volunteers to ascertain their suitability for and interest in that position. The interview should determine the qualifications of the volunteer, their commitment to fulfill the requirements of the position, and should answer any questions that the volunteer might have about the position. Interviews may be conducted either in person or by other means.

Volunteer Resources will conduct monthly interviews to identify qualified volunteers that meet the current needs of the company and surrounding communities. Qualified candidates will be invited to participate in any necessary training prior to the assignment and/or referred to a location for placement.

Staff may interview and select volunteers for service. Staff must complete the administrative section on the volunteer application and send it to Volunteer Resources for approval before scheduling the volunteer for service. Volunteer Resources will review the candidate's application and acquire all necessary documentation. When the volunteer is approved, Volunteer Resources will contact the interviewer and supervisor. Volunteer service may not begin until Volunteer Resources approves the applicant.

Criminal Records Check

As appropriate for the protection of customers and staff, volunteers in certain assignments may be asked to submit to a background criminal check. Volunteers who do not agree to the background check may be refused assignment.

Placement with Children

Where volunteers are to be placed in direct contact with children, additional screening procedures are instituted. Adult candidates interested in working with children must submit to a criminal background check as outlined in the Fair Credit Reporting Act prior to acceptance as a volunteer. In addition, the organization may conduct reference checks. Volunteers who refuse permission for conduct of these checks will not be accepted for placement. Information gathered through reference checks and background checks will not necessarily preclude an individual from volunteering. This information will be used only for the volunteer-related purposes and only to the extent permitted by applicable law.

Placement
In placing a volunteer in a position, attention shall be paid to the interests and capabilities of the volunteer and to the requirements of the volunteer position. No placement shall be made unless the requirements of both the volunteer and the supervising staff can be met.

Staff
Staff who will be working with the volunteer should participate in interviewing and placement whenever possible. Volunteers are also interviewed and referred to staff by Volunteer Resources. Final assignment of a potential volunteer should not take place without the consent of appropriate staff with whom the volunteer will be working.

Identification for Volunteers
All volunteers will be issued a volunteer badge upon placement. Program specific badges must be worn while volunteering and returned to the volunteer supervisor on the last day of volunteer service.

Acceptance and Appointment
Service as a volunteer shall begin with an official notice of acceptance or appointment to a volunteer position. Notice may only be given by an authorized representative, who will normally be a staff member of Volunteer Resources or the volunteer site supervisor. No volunteer shall begin performance of any position until they have been officially accepted for that position and have completed all necessary screening and paperwork. At the time of final acceptance, each volunteer shall complete all necessary enrollment paperwork and agreement of service with the organization.

Probationary Period
All volunteer placements shall initially be done on a trial period of 30 days. At the end of this period a second interview of the volunteer shall be conducted by the volunteer supervisor, at which point either the volunteer or staff may request a re-assignment of the volunteer to a different position or may determine the unsuitability of the volunteer for a position within the organization.

Re-Assignment
Volunteers who are at any time re-assigned to a new position shall be interviewed for that position and shall receive all appropriate orientation and training for that position before they begin work. In addition, any screening procedures appropriate for that specific position must be completed, even if the volunteer has already been working with the organization.

Length of Service
All volunteer positions shall have a set term of duration. It is highly recommended that this term shall not be longer than one-year, with an option for renewal at the discretion of both parties. All volunteer assignments shall end at the conclusion of their set term, without expectation or requirement of re-assignment of that position to the incumbent.

Volunteers are neither expected nor required to accept further service in a position at the end of their set term, although they are welcome to do so in most cases, but may instead seek a different volunteer assignment within the organization, or may retire from volunteer service.

Leave of Absence
At the discretion of the supervisor, leaves of absence may be granted to volunteers. This leave of absence will not alter or extend the previously agreed upon ending date of the volunteer's term of service.

Volunteer Training and Development

Orientation
All volunteers will receive a general orientation on the nature and purpose of the Organization, an orientation on the nature and operation of the program or activity for which they are recruited, and a specific orientation on the purposes and requirements of the position which they are accepting in that effort. All volunteers must review policy manual and comply with all applicable policies and procedures.

Volunteer Resources Training Courses
Volunteer training prior to placement is provided by Volunteer Resources for the majority of assignments. Upon successful completion of the training and paperwork, Volunteer Resources will refer approved volunteers to supervisors.

Staff Involvement in Orientation and Training
Staff members responsible over delivery of services should have an active role in the design and delivery of both orientation and training of volunteers. Those staff who will supervise volunteers shall have primary responsibility for design and delivery of on-the-job training to volunteers assigned to them.

On-the-Job Training
Volunteers will receive specific on-the-job training by a staff member as designated by the Agency or Department Head to provide them with the information and skills necessary to perform their volunteer assignment. The timing and methods for delivery of such training should be appropriate to the complexity and demands of the position and the capabilities of the volunteer.

To maximize volunteer productivity, duties should be planned in discussion with the volunteer. Volunteer assignments should be designed to meet or expand Agency or Department goals which are not normally carried out by salaried staff, providing for task diversity and increasing responsibility over time. The supervisor should also prepare staff for involvement with volunteers as well as offer the volunteer ongoing training, constructive feedback and otherwise plan and manage the development of the volunteer. Where appropriate and possible, volunteer development activities may go on at the local, regional or systemwide level through the Office of Volunteer Resources.

Volunteer Involvement in Orientation and Training
Experienced volunteers should be included in the design and delivery of volunteer orientation and training.

Continuing Education
Just as staff, volunteers should attempt to improve their levels of skill during their terms of service. Additional training and educational opportunities should be made available to volunteers during their connection with the company. This continuing education may include both additional information on performance

of their current volunteer assignment as well as more general information, and might be provided either by the company or by assisting the volunteer to participate in educational programs provided by other groups.

Volunteer Supervision and Evaluation

Requirement of a Supervisor
Each volunteer who is accepted to a position with the company must have a clearly identified supervisor who is responsible for direct management of that volunteer. This supervisor shall be responsible for day-to-day management and guidance of the work of the volunteer, and shall be available to the volunteer for consultation and assistance.

Volunteer/Staff Relationships
Volunteers and staff are considered to be partners in implementing the mission and programs of the company, with each having a complementary role to play. It is essential for the proper operation of this relationship that each partner understand and respect the needs and abilities of the other.

Acceptance of Volunteers by Staff
Since individual staff members are in a better position to determine the requirements of their work and their own abilities, no volunteer will be assigned to work with a staff person without the consent of that staff person. Since volunteers are considered a valuable resource in performing BPL's work, staff are encouraged to seriously consider creative ways in which volunteers might be of service and to consult with Volunteer Resources if they feel in need of assistance or additional training.

Staff Volunteer Management Training
An orientation on working with volunteers will be provided to all staff. In-service training on effective volunteer utilization will be provided to those staff members who are highly involved in volunteer management.

Volunteer Feedback for Employee Supervisors
Examination of effective engagement of volunteers will be periodically conducted by Volunteer Resources through staff and volunteer surveys. Feedback will be shared with volunteer supervisors and mentors to build best practices in volunteer supervision and program development.

Absenteeism
Volunteers are expected to perform their duties on a regular scheduled and timely basis. If expecting to be absent from a scheduled duty, volunteers should inform their staff supervisor as far in advance as possible so that alternative arrangements may be made. Continual absenteeism will result in a review of the volunteer's work assignment or term of service.

Evaluations
Volunteers shall receive periodic evaluations to review their work. The evaluation session is utilized to review the performance of the volunteer, to suggest any changes in work style, to seek suggestions from the volunteer on means of enhancing the volunteer's relationship with the company, to convey appreciation to the volunteer, and to ascertain the continued interest of the volunteer in serving in that position. Evaluations should include both an examination of the volunteer's performance of position responsibilities and a discussion of any suggestions that the volunteer may have concerning the position or project with which

the volunteer is connected. The evaluation session is an opportunity for both the volunteer and the company to examine and improve their relationship.

Written Basis for Evaluation
The position description and standards of performance for a volunteer position should form the basis of an evaluation. A written record should be kept of each evaluation session. The Volunteer Evaluation form (#) is available on intranet.

Staff Responsibility for Evaluation
It shall be the responsibility of each staff person in a supervisory relationship with a volunteer to schedule and perform periodic evaluations and to send evaluations to Volunteer Resources for record keeping.

Corrective Action
In appropriate situations, corrective action may be taken following an evaluation. Staff should seek the consultation and assistance of the Manager of Volunteer Resources prior to taking corrective action. Examples of corrective action include the requirement of additional training, re-assignment of a volunteer to a new position, or dismissal from volunteer service.

Dismissal of a Volunteer
Volunteers who do not adhere to the rules and procedures of the company or who fail to satisfactorily perform their volunteer assignment are subject to dismissal. Prior to dismissal of a volunteer, staff should seek the consultation and assistance of the Manager of Volunteer Resources.

Reasons for Dismissal
Possible grounds for dismissal may include, but are not limited to, the following: gross misconduct or insubordination, being under the influence of alcohol or drugs, theft of property or misuse of company equipment or materials, abuse or mistreatment of customers or co-workers, failure to abide by the company policies and procedures, failure to meet physical or mental standards of performance, and failure to satisfactorily perform assigned duties.

Concerns and Grievances
Decisions involving corrective action of a volunteer may be reviewed for appropriateness. If corrective action is taken, the affected volunteer shall be informed of the procedures for expressing their concern or grievance.

Notice of Departure or Re-Assignment of a Volunteer
In the event that a volunteer leaves the organization, whether voluntarily or involuntarily, or is re-assigned to a new position, it shall be the responsibility of Volunteer Resources to inform those affected staff that the volunteer is no longer assigned to work with them. In cases of dismissal for cause, this notification should be given in writing and should clearly indicate that any further contact with the volunteer is outside any scope of relationship with the organization.

Resignation
Volunteers may resign from their volunteer service at any time. It is requested that volunteers who intend to resign provide advance notice of their departure and a reason for their decision.

Exit Interviews
Exit interviews, where possible, should be conducted with volunteers who are leaving their positions. The interview should ascertain why the volunteer is leaving the position, suggestions the volunteer may have to improving the position, and the possibility of involving the volunteer in some other capacity with the organization.

Communication with Volunteer Resources
Staff who are supervising volunteers are responsible for maintaining regular communication with Volunteer Resources on the status of volunteers, and are responsible for the timely provision of all necessary paperwork to the Department. The Department should be informed immediately of any substantial change in the work or status of a volunteer and should be consulted in advance before any corrective action is taken.

Evaluation of Volunteer Engagement
Volunteer Resources shall conduct an annual evaluation of the engagement of volunteers by the company. This evaluation shall include information gathered from volunteers, staff, and customers.

Volunteer Support and Recognition

Access to Property and Materials
As appropriate, volunteers shall have access to property and materials necessary to fulfill their duties, and shall receive training in the operation of any equipment. Property and materials shall be utilized only when directly required for purposes. This policy does not include access to or use of the company vehicles which is prohibited.

Insurance
Liability and accident insurance is provided for all registered volunteers acting within the scope of their volunteer assignment. [Volunteers are encouraged to consult with their own insurance agents regarding the extension of their personal insurance to include community volunteer work.] Specific information regarding such insurance is available from Volunteer Resources.

All registered volunteers have Worker's Compensation coverage while they are performing volunteer service for the company. In case of an accident, an Incident Report Form should be completed and forwarded to the Office of Volunteer Resources.

INCOME TAX DEDUCTION
Current IRS regulations allow volunteers to deduct the cost of transportation to and from their volunteer work site for income tax purposes. When using public transportation the deduction equals the amount spent. If using a private automobile, the deduction equals a scheduled mileage allowance. The current allowance can be found in the instructions for completing IRS form 1040. It is the responsibility of the volunteer to determine his/her allowable deduction.

Recognition
An annual volunteer recognition event will be conducted to highlight and reward the contribution of volunteers to the company.

Informal Recognition
All staff responsible for volunteer supervision are encouraged to undertake on-going methods of recognition of volunteer service on a regular basis throughout the year. These methods of informal recognition should range from simple ‘"Thank You" note/letter to a concerted effort to include volunteers as full participants in program decision making and implementation.

Staff Recognition
Volunteer Resources shall maintain a program for recognition of staff who work well with volunteers and shall consult with volunteers to identify appropriate staff to receive such awards.

IV. Responsibilities:

Executive Director's Office
Releases policy

Information Technology
Includes policy on Intranet

Office of Volunteer Resources
Monitors policy implementation
Provides ongoing policy review

Supervisor/Agency Head
Monitors and evaluates performance of volunteer staff

Issuing Agency: Office of Volunteer Resources
Policy approved by Board of Trustees: December 16, 2008

Related documents:
Volunteer Application (#273.00)
Parental Permission Letter
Volunteer Time Sheet (#273.04)
Volunteer Request
Volunteer Code of Conduct (available January 2009)
Volunteer Evaluation (available January 2009)

Supersedes policy #: None
Related policies: None